

HOW TO PROPERLY RESPOND TO THE EXPERIENCES OF LIFE

(BROWN FONT DENOTES INSTRUCTIONS TO
TECHNICIAN)

(BLUE FONT DENOTES POWER POINT SLIDE)

TEXT: Jeremiah 29:8-14 (NLT) *“The LORD Almighty, the God of Israel, says, “Do not let the prophets and mediums who are there in Babylon trick you. Do not listen to their dreams ⁹ because they prophesy lies in my name. I have not sent them,” says the LORD. ¹⁰ “The truth is that you will be in Babylon for seventy years. But then I will come and do for you all the good things I have promised, and I will bring you home again. ¹¹ For I know the plans I have for you,” says the LORD. “They are plans for good and not for disaster, to give you a future and a hope. ¹² In those days when you pray, I will listen. ¹³ If you look for me in earnest, you will find me when you seek me. ¹⁴ I will be found by you,” says the LORD. “I will end your captivity and restore your fortunes. I will gather you out of the nations where I sent you and bring you home again to your own land.”*

INTRO: In this passage of Scripture Israel has been taken captive by the Babylonians and their captivity is becoming more than a little bothersome. It is against this backdrop that the Lord speaks to Israel and tells

them several things: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- He assures them that He will fulfill His promises...
- He guarantees they will be returning to their homeland...
- He promises them hope and a future of freedom...
- He pledges to hear their prayers...
- He reassures them that their captivity will end...
- He vows to return their fortunes to them...

In this instance, the promises and assurances being made by Jehovah to a group of people enslaved by their arch enemy is encouraging indeed. The same promises He made to them can still be claimed by each child of God. *Will we receive His promises?*

(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL NEXT SLIDE)

What had happened to Israel to place them in a position of being enslaved by their enemies to begin with? After all, they are Gods chosen people, right? While it is true they sinned against the Lord, the fact is that life happens, and when it does a host of experiences come along with it.

Life is a wonderful gift given to each of us by our creator. Someone said, *"Each day is a gift from God,*

that's why we call it the present." **(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL THE NEXT SLIDE)** While life is a wonderful gift as well as a tremendous opportunity to experiment in the human experience, it also possesses the ability of throwing its participants some curves.

Whether you are an optimist or a pessimist will have a lot to do with the joy you experience along the journey of life. **(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL THE NEXT SLIDE)**

Salvation in the life of the believer should change the glass from being half empty to being half full. Nehemiah 8:10 (NKJV) ***"Then he said to them, "Go your way, eat the fat, drink the sweet, and send portions to those for whom nothing is prepared; for this day is holy to our LORD. Do not sorrow, for the joy of the LORD is your strength."*** Psalms 137:1-4 (NKJV) ***"By the rivers of Babylon, There we sat down, yea, we wept When we remembered Zion.²We hung our harps Upon the willows in the midst of it ³ For there those who carried us away captive asked of us a song, And those who plundered us requested mirth, Saying, "Sing us one of the songs of Zion!" ⁴How shall we sing the LORD's song In a foreign land?"***

(A little girl was walking home from school and it was lightning very badly – Her mother was coming to meet her and thought she would probably be very much

afraid – When she and her mother embraced her mother said, “*Were you afraid?*” “*Why mommy? Jesus was just taking my picture.*” The girl replied!)

I think if all of us would be completely honest, we would have to say that life contains more blessings than difficulties.

I choose by an act of my own will to allow the joy of the Lord to operate in my life no matter what the circumstances may be.

The Apostle Paul said, Acts 26:1-2 (NKJV) “***Then Agrippa said to Paul, “You are permitted to speak for yourself.” So Paul stretched out his hand and answered for himself: ²“I think myself happy, King Agrippa, because today I shall answer for myself before you concerning all the things of which I am accused by the Jews.”*** I know this Scripture is taken out of context but the essence of this is found from Genesis to Revelation and must be lived out in our lives if we are to properly respond to God in the experiences of life. Each of us has a choice to make; we can either think ourselves happy; or we can think ourselves sad. (My conversation with a guy who said he was a realist.)

Over the next five weeks we are going to talk about how to properly respond to: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Happy experiences...
- Difficult experiences...
- Quiet experiences...
- Painful experiences...
- Every experience...

I. DURING HAPPY EXPERIENCES WE SHOULD PRAISE GOD!

James 1:17 (NKJV) ***“Every good gift and every perfect gift is from above, and comes down from the Father of lights, with whom there is no variation or shadow of turning.”***

Life is filled with many experiences. No roller coaster in the world can offer the exhilarating highs and the depressing lows, and everything in between which one will experience during our journey through life. While there are countless experiences in life, it is my opinion that the good far outweighs the bad. I choose to be an optimist and see the glass half full rather than half empty. I want us to look at some of the happy experiences in life and how we can properly respond during those times.

Happy experiences in life include: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Holidays...
- Birthdays...
- Vacations...

- Family times...
- Educational accomplishments...
- Marriage...
- Anniversaries...
- The birth of a child...
- The marriage of a child...
- Retirement...

I realize this is not by any means an exhaustive list, but these events certainly bring about some happy times.

The response we display during happy times will determine many things about our future: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- It charts a course going forward...
- It develops a measuring stick for all other experiences...
- It determines the perception of others toward us...

Our lives will be defined by the sum total of the choices we make. When we die, no minister will be a good enough orator to change the legacy we have created by our choices. Proverbs 22:1 (NKJV) “***A good name is to be chosen rather than great riches.***”

Albert Schweitzer said, “*Success is not the key to happiness. Happiness is the key to success. If you love what you are doing, you will be successful.*”

Though many happy moments will no doubt occur in our lives, the one thing we never want to do is gloat or become braggadocios with regard to these events. The reason we do not want to ever do this is because in so doing we take the credit, when the glory really belongs to God.

The proper response to happy times is to give God praise. When we give God praise for the good things which have happened to us, we acknowledge that we are totally reliant upon Him for all of the blessings of life. James 1:17 (NKJV) **“Every good gift and every perfect gift is from above, and comes down from the Father of lights, with whom there is no variation or shadow of turning.”**

Think about this, without the help of the Lord:
(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- We would not have a family to celebrate the good times with...
- We would not have the mental capacity to acquire an education which would support us in life...
- We would not have a church family to keep us encouraged in the difficult times...
- We would be bound for eternal separation from the creator of the universe...
- We would have no hope beyond this life...

If it were not for the Lord working in our lives some of the experiences of life would eliminate the joy of the journey. True joy comes from the Lord. Benjamin Franklin once said, *“The Constitution only guarantees the American people the right to pursue happiness. You have to catch it yourself.”*

There is an old song which says *“Without Him I could do nothing. Without Him I’d surely fail. Without Him I would be drifting, like a ship without a sail.”*

Think about how devastating it would be to not have a personal relationship with Jesus! Would there be any true joy at all in our lives? I seriously doubt that we would!

I’m sure all of us greatly appreciate all the good times, but we need to be careful to properly respond by giving Him all of the praise!

II. DURING DIFFICULT EXPERIENCES WE SHOULD SEEK GOD!

Psalms 34:1-4 (NKJV) ***“I will bless the LORD at all times; His praise shall continually be in my mouth. ²My soul shall make its boast in the LORD; The humble shall hear of it and be glad.³ Oh, magnify the LORD with me, And let us exalt His name together.⁴ I sought the LORD, and He heard me, And delivered me from all my fears.”***

In this series of sermons we have been looking at how we should respond when life comes at us with all kinds of experiences and challenges. The **life experience which we have discussed and the proper response is:**
(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- In happy experiences we should praise God...

Today we are going to talk about seeking God in the difficult experiences of life.

In this passage of Scripture the Psalmist makes his audience aware of several things with regard to the experiences of life:

- He decides to praise God, no matter what was transpiring in his life...
- He made up his mind that any boasting must be with regard to the greatness of God...
- Those who have been humbled by the experiences of life will hear of his decision to seek God in difficult times, and it will be an encouragement to them...
- He welcomes all his hearers, readers, and followers to join him in worship of the God who has power over the experiences of life...
- He makes his audience aware of the need to seek God in difficult times and to believe he hears their prayers, which will result in God delivering them from all their trouble...

Difficulty is a common denominator for all human beings. It makes little difference whether you are from: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- A prominent or obscure family...
- An educated or uneducated experience...
- An impoverished or affluent background....
- A developed nation or a third world country...

Difficulty will flow in and out of your life no matter where you come from or who you are related to! Peter Marshall said, *“When we long for a life without difficulty, we need to be reminded that an oak tree grows strong in adverse winds and that diamonds are formed under pressure.”*

Jesus said, John 16:31 (NKJV) ***“These things I have spoken to you, that in Me you may have peace. In the world you will have tribulation; but be of good cheer, I have overcome the world.”***

The fact is, as long as we live in this world full of trouble, we will face our fair share of difficult situations. How we deal with difficulty will go a long ways toward defining who we are and how we will be remembered. **(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL THE NEXT SLIDE)**

One of the things I want to make abundantly clear; for the Christian, all difficulty can be traced to one of two sources:

- We have sinned by stepping outside the protection of Gods care... (God placed a hedge around Job and God has a hedge of protection around all Christians) (The only way the devil could attack Job was to either get him out from behind Gods hedge of protection or secure the consent of the Lord to attack Job and his family) (Nothing has changed) James 1 :14-15 (KJV) ***“Every man is tempted, when he is drawn away of his own lust, and enticed. ¹⁵Then when lust hath conceived, it bringeth forth sin: and sin, when it is finished, bringeth forth death.”***
- The difficulty has been allowed by the Lord... (God measured the faith of Job and measured the test, declaring Job strong enough to endure the testing) Job 1:6-12 (NKJV) ***“Now there was a day when the sons of God came to present themselves before the LORD, and Satan also came among them. ⁷And the LORD said to Satan, “From where do you come?” So Satan answered the LORD and said, “From going to and fro on the earth, and from walking back and forth on it.” ⁸Then the LORD said to Satan, “Have you considered My servant Job, that there is none like him on the earth, a blameless and upright man, one who fears God and shuns evil?” ⁹So Satan answered the LORD and said, “Does Job fear God for nothing? ¹⁰“Have You not made a hedge around him, around his***

household, and around all that he has on every side? You have blessed the work of his hands, and his possessions have increased in the land.
¹¹*“But now, stretch out Your hand and touch all that he has, and he will surely curse You to Your face!”* ¹²*And the LORD said to Satan,*
“Behold, all that he has is in your power; only do not lay a hand on his person.” So Satan went out from the presence of the LORD.”

The first kind of difficulty is self-inflicted and is eternally destructive. When we step outside the protection of God’s grace, we open up ourselves to difficulty which will never turn out for good.

(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL THE NEXT SLIDE)

This is self-inflicted, self-destructive behavior. 1 Timothy 6:7-10 (NKJV) “*We brought nothing into this world, and it is certain we can carry nothing out.* ⁸*And having food and clothing, with these we shall be content.* ⁹*But those who desire to be rich fall into temptation and a snare, and into many foolish and harmful lusts which drown men in destruction and perdition.* ¹⁰*For the love of money is a root of all kinds of evil, for which some have strayed from the faith in their greediness, and pierced themselves through with many sorrows.*”

The second kind of difficulty has passed through the clearing house of God! Our Heavenly Father has pre-measured the difficulty before it was initiated in our

lives and He has deemed our faith sufficient for the test! When this kind of difficulty ends several things will have transpired: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- The work of Satan will have been defeated...
- The Believer will have been strengthened...
- God will have received the glory...

Phyllis Buttone said, *“There are two ways to meet difficulty; you alter the difficulty; or you alter yourself to meet the difficulty.”* When a believer senses the onslaught of difficult situations and times, the first thing one should do is to seek the Lord! Why should one seek God when difficulty arises? **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- To determine whether sin is present...
- To determine whether one is in the will of God...
- To determine how the Lord would want one to react...

Think of all the people who followed this matrix to its successful conclusion: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Moses at the Red Sea...
- David when fleeing from Saul...
- Daniel in the Lion’s Den...

- [Paul and Silas in prison...](#) (At midnight they prayed and sang praises to God – God responded with an earthquake – The Philippian Jailer and his entire family were converted)
- [John the Revelator on the Island of Patmos...](#)

John Wesley, one of the great preachers of the past, knew what it meant to endure trials. Listen to these excerpts from his diary:

- Sunday, A.M., May 5 Preached in St. Anne's... Was asked not to come back anymore.
- Sunday, P.M., May 5 Preached in St. John's... Deacons said, "*Get out and stay out.*"
- Sunday, A.M., May 12 Preached in St. Jude's... Can't go back there, either.
- Sunday, A.M., May 19 Preached in St. Somebody Else's... Deacons called special meeting and said I couldn't return.
- Sunday, P.M., May 19 Preached on street... Kicked off street.
- Sunday, A.M., May 26 Preached in meadow... Chased out of meadow, as bull was turned loose during service.
- Sunday, A.M., June 2 Preached out at the edge of town... Kicked off the highway.
- Sunday, P.M., June 2 [This] Afternoon [I] preached in a pasture... Ten thousand people came out to hear me.

What does this say to us? Keep on preaching, keep on believing, keep on trusting, keep on working, keep on fighting, and victory will come our way! I don't know about you, but that encourages me!

If seeking the Lord when confronted with difficult experiences worked for a who's who like this, I think it will work for us!

I want to finish this subject with one Scripture which I think will be an encouragement to all who are grappling with difficulty. Psalms 37:23-25 (NLT)

“The steps of the godly are directed by the LORD. He delights in every detail of their lives.”²⁴Though they stumble, they will not fall, for the LORD holds them by the hand.²⁵Once I was young, and now I am old. Yet I have never seen the godly forsaken, nor seen their children begging for bread.”

III. IN QUITE EXPERIENCES WE SHOULD WORSHIP GOD!

Matthew 11:28-30 (NKJV) ***“Come to Me, all you who labor and are heavy laden, and I will give you rest.***

²⁹***“Take My yoke upon you and learn from Me, for I am gentle and lowly in heart, and you will find rest for your souls.*** ³⁰***“For My yoke is easy and My burden is light.”***

In this series of sermons we have been looking at how we should respond when life comes at us with all kinds

of experiences and challenges. The life experiences we have discussed and the proper responses are:

(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- In happy experiences we should praise God...
- In difficult experiences we should seek God...

Today we are going to talk about worshipping God in the quiet times experiences of life.

Of all the experiences of life, quiet times may be the times which are the rarest of all times. I would like to define the quiet times of life in this way:

“Quiet times are when nothing is going wrong; nothing is going overly well; everything is on an even keel.”

(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL THE NEXT SLIDE)

One can create times of rest, but God occasionally leads us into purposeful times of rest. These are periodic stages which we will identify as quiet places. It is my opinion that if there is not a certain amount of quiet times in our lives we would self-destruct. The human body is not capable of continually carrying a tremendous load of stress forever; and it is not capable of living in a constant state of euphoria. Quiet times are essential for our physical and spiritual health and well being. **(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL THE NEXT SLIDE)**

Jesus was well aware of this and He addresses this in our text. Jesus is saying: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- If we are carrying a heavy burden we can bring it to Him...
- When we take our burden to the Lord He always provides support...
- When our burdens are cast upon the Lord we find rest for our souls...
- He will bear our burdens and assist us in not over-encumbering ourselves...

There is an old song which goes something like this; *“Leave it there. Leave it there. Take your burden to the Lord and leave it there. If you’ll trust and never doubt, He will surely bring you out. Take your burden to the Lord and leave it there.”*

I want to take a quick look at what Jesus is saying when He say’s; ***“You will find rest for your souls.”***

Man is made up of: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- **Body...** This is the physical structure of who we are. It is referred to in Scripture as a; house; temple; house of this tabernacle; and even a tent.
- **Spirit...** The spirit of a person is the God conscious part of who we are. The spirit is what is made right at conversion, not the body or

soul. The battle all of us face beginning at conversion is that the spirit is made right and a war ensues as the spirit attempts to bring the body and soul into line with the Word of God and this new life in Christ.

- **Soul...** The soul is our mind, our will and our emotions. The soul is that part of us which possesses the ability to touch; taste; feel; see; smell; reason; these are all a part of the soul. We could say that the soul is the sensual part of a person.

The truth is; I live in a body; I possess a spirit; I am a living soul. It is interesting to me that Jesus said,

“You will find rest for your souls.” Think of this:
(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- When the body has had enough it WILL demand rest...
- When the spirit has become depleted it will drive one to his knees...
- When the soul has been overloaded it usually requires a conscious decision on the part of the individual to seek rest...

Trust me, soul rest is not only nice and welcomed, it is a necessary part of healthy living both physically and spiritually.

Elbert Hubbard said, *“The man who doesn't relax and hoot a few hoots voluntarily, now and then, is in great danger of hooting hoots and standing on his head for the edification of the psychiatrist and trained nurse, a little later on.”*

The Lord leads us into places of periodic rest; he has placed some roadside rest stops on the highway to heaven! The Psalmist phrased it in this way, Psalms 23:1-3 (CEV) *“You, LORD, are my shepherd. I will never be in need. ² You let me rest in fields of green grass. You lead me to streams of peaceful water, ³ and you refresh my life. You are true to your name, and you lead me along the right paths.”* According to this Scripture God intentionally provides: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Times of rest...
- Times of peace...
- Times of refreshing...

Why would God provide such things as rest, peace, and refreshing? **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- He provides such times in order to re-connect us with what is really important in life...
- He makes the rest stops available to keep us on the right path...

Have you ever taken a long trip and because you were driving far more hours than what would be considered safe, you made a wrong turn or could not remember certain parts of the trip? This is what can happen to us without some quiet times. (Florida trip)

Most of us have a tendency to create new activity during quiet times, simply because we do not know what to do with ourselves during such times! Jennifer Yane said, *“I try to take one day at a time, but sometimes several days attack me at once.”*

We should maximize the precious moments of quiet times which come from the Lord by taking the time to worship Him! A.W. Tozer said, *“Without worship, we go about miserable.”* **(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL THE NEXT SLIDE.)**

We should use the quiet time to draw close to God through worship! Jack Hayford said, *“Worship changes the worshipper into the image of the one worshipped.”* How can we see to it that this happens?

- During the quiet times we do not have the other competing distractions; we should turn our focus on the Lord and allow Him to fill our thoughts...
- During the quiet times we are not so encumbered with the cares of life and we should take some time to be alone in His presence and

just communicate with Him through His Word...

- During the quiet times we are not being pulled into every decision that is going on in the world, and we should take some time to worship through prayer.
- During the quiet times our mind is clear of some of the other obstructions of life, and we should take some time to sing to the Lord both with songs of inspiration and a new song to the Lord...

Someone said, *“The mark of a successful man is one that has spent an entire day on the bank of a river without feeling guilty about it.”*

Remember, Jesus took time to rest and we must as well! God even rested from His labor of building and populating the world! Genesis 2:1-3 (NKJV) ***“Thus the heavens and the earth, and all the host of them, were finished. ²And on the seventh day God ended His work which He had done, and He rested on the seventh day from all His work which He had done. ³Then God blessed the seventh day and sanctified it, because in it He rested from all His work which God had created and made.”*** We would do well to remember that resting is still a commandment of God; in fact, it is the fourth commandment to be exact! Exodus 20:8-11 (NKJV) ***“Remember the Sabbath day, to keep it holy. ⁹Six days you shall labor and do***

all your work, ¹⁰but the seventh day is the Sabbath of the LORD your God. In it you shall do no work: you, nor your son, nor your daughter, nor your male servant, nor your female servant, nor your cattle, nor your stranger who is within your gates. ¹¹For in six days the LORD made the heavens and the earth, the sea, and all that is in them, and rested the seventh day. Therefore the LORD blessed the Sabbath day and hallowed it.” There is more verbiage with regard to this day of rest than any of the other commandments!

Man was not genetically engineered for a long shelf life if he does not have quiet times and times of rest, relaxation, and refreshing! If we want to be effective over the long haul we must welcome, enjoy, and learn to worship in the quiet times.

Finally, remember the following things about the quiet times: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- We should welcome quiet times...
- We should learn to enjoy quiet times...
- We should learn to create quiet times...
- We should resist activity during quiet times...
- We should not forget to worship during quiet times...

IV. IN PAINFUL EXPERIENCES WE SHOULD TRUST GOD!

Proverbs 3:5-6 (NKJV) “Trust in the LORD with all your heart, And lean not on your own understanding;⁶ *In all your ways acknowledge Him, And He shall direct your paths.*”

In this series of sermons we have been looking at how we should respond when life comes at us with all kinds of experiences and challenges. The life experiences we have discussed and the proper responses are:

(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- In happy experiences we should praise God...
- In difficult experiences we should seek God...
- In quiet experiences we should worship God...

Today we are going to talk about trusting God in the painful experiences of life.

Pain is an emotion which if not properly dealt with can dull the senses and leave one critical or worse yet, bitter. None of us can afford to have this happen to us so it is imperative that we learn to properly respond to pain. The proper response to pain is to trust God. This is probably the most difficult thing to do of any response we could have, but we can be assured it is the most beneficial response. Trusting God in painful experiences is the right thing to do for: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Ourselves...

- Our family...
- Our church...
- Our acquaintances...
- Our walk with God...

Pain can be brought into our lives from many sources:

- Our family can create pain...
- We can create pain for ourselves...
- Friends and acquaintances can create pain...
- Accidents and health incidents can create pain...
- Unforeseen financial difficulties can create pain...

More times than not, painful experiences come upon us quite suddenly and unexpectedly.

Because painful experiences seem to come upon us without prior notice they present challenges which are extremely difficult to handle. The Word of God addresses the issue of unexpected painful experiences. Proverbs 3:25-26 (KJV)

“Do not be afraid of sudden terror, Nor of trouble from the wicked when it comes; ²⁶ For the LORD will be your confidence, And will keep your foot from being caught.”

There are two ways for the child of God to respond in times of unexpected painful experiences: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- **Panic...** This response helps no one and even serves to complicate the matter. 2 Timothy 1:7 (NKJV) ***“God has not given us a spirit of fear, but of power and of love and of a sound mind.”*** (My Mom & Dad’s response when my sister was bitten by a poisonous snake)
- **Trust...** It is for certain the situation will not be made better through panic, so the proper response is to trust the Lord. Trust is the demonstration of faith! (My Dad’s response when my sister was bitten by a poisonous snake)

The fact is that all of us will deal with a certain amount of pain in our lives, how we deal with it will determine our future and will also establish how others see us.

Trusting God is easier to talk about than to do. **(PLAY GEICO COMMERCIAL HERE)**

In her book “Gateway to Joy, Elisabeth Elliot said, ***“God is God. Because He is God, He is worthy of my trust and obedience. I will find rest nowhere but in His holy will; a will that is unspeakably beyond my largest notions of what He is up to.”*** **(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL THE NEXT SLIDE)**

The reason it is so difficult for us to trust God is because human help is right at our fingertips! **Think of**

this: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- If we are having family problems we can call a counselor...
- If we are having financial problems we can call a banker...
- If we are having emotional problems we can call a psychiatrist or psychologist...
- If we are having problems finding a job we can call a head hunter...

I am not personally opposed to human help and resources but I think that because of its availability and accessibility we often miss out on the adventure of trusting God! Painful experiences usually place us in a position of making a decision of trusting man or trusting God! I think I would rather take my chances on God! Vernon Paterson said, *"There are always uncertainties ahead, but there is always one certainty-- God's will is good."* **(LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL THE NEXT SLIDE)**

In attempting to discover how to properly respond to painful experiences I do not think we would find a Bible character with more expertise on the subject than a man named Job. Job had more than a little pain to deal with in his life. Consider this about Job: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Job loved, followed, and respected God... Job 1:1 (NKJV) ***“There was a man in the land of Uz, whose name was Job; and that man was blameless and upright, and one who feared God...”***
- Job did nothing to initiate the pain in his life; his pain was created in a conversation between God and the devil... Job 1:6-12 (NKJV) ***“Now there was a day when the sons of God came to present themselves before the LORD, and Satan also came among them. (The devil is not repelled by the presence of God, he is actually attracted to it) ⁷And the LORD said to Satan, “From where do you come?” So Satan answered the LORD and said, “From going to and fro on the earth, and from walking back and forth on it.” ⁸Then the LORD said to Satan, “Have you considered My servant Job, that there is none like him on the earth, a blameless and upright man, one who fears God and shuns evil?” (Wow, talk about high recommendations) ⁹So Satan answered the LORD and said, “Does Job fear God for nothing? ¹⁰“Have You not made a hedge around him, around his household, and around all that he has on every side? You have blessed the work of his hands, and his possessions have increased in the land. (The accusation was that Job was serving God for***

what he could get – I wonder if we could pass the smell test on this?) ¹¹**“But now, stretch out Your hand and touch all that he has, and he will surely curse You to Your face!”** ¹²**And the LORD said to Satan, “Behold, all that he has is in your power; only do not lay a hand on his person.”** So Satan went out from the presence of the LORD.” The pain in Job’s life was initiated by God bragging about him to the devil!

- Job stood against evil and injustice... Job 1:1 (NKJV) ***“There was a man in the land of Uz, whose name was Job; and that man was blameless and upright, and one who feared God and shunned evil.”***
- Job had a sub-par support group which dealt him even more grief... His friends and his wife spent seven days and nights attempting to unearth a reason for his pain. His wife, who should have been his strongest supporter makes a startling statement in Job 2:9 (NKJV) ***“Then his wife said to him, “Do you still hold fast to your integrity? Curse God and die!”***
- Job knew God would develop the greater good in his life... Listen to how Job answers the ridiculous remarks of his own wife, Job 2:10 (NKJV) ***“You speak as one of the foolish women speaks. Shall we indeed accept good***

from God, and shall we not accept adversity?"

In all this Job did not sin with his lips."

- **Job trusted God...** Job 13:15-16 (NKJV) "*Though He slay me, yet will I trust Him. Even so, I will defend my own ways before Him.* ¹⁶*He also shall be my salvation...*" Seven times the book of Job employs the word trust. Job was a trusting man; he trusted God and God alone! God trusted Job! Do we trust God? Can God trust us?

- **Job was a patient man...** He patiently endured the pain and received the reward for all the suffering! Job 42:10 (NKJV) "*And the LORD turned the captivity of Job, when he prayed for his friends: also the LORD gave Job twice as much as he had before.*" **JOB'S WEALTH**

BEFORE THE TRIAL: 7,000 sheep @

\$245.00 each - \$1,715,000.00; 3,000 camels.@

\$3,500.00 each -\$10,500,000.00; 1,000 oxen @

\$600.00 each - \$600,000.00; 500 Donkeys

@\$600.00 each - \$300,000.00; **TOTAL**

ESTIMATED VALUE: \$13,115,000.00 -

JOB'S WEALTH AFTER THE TRIAL:

14,000 sheep @ \$245.00 each -\$3,430,000.00;

6,000 camels @ \$3,500.00 each -

\$21,000,000.00; 2,000 oxen @ \$600.00 each -

\$1,200,000.00; 1,000 Donkeys @ \$600.00 each

- \$600,000.00; **TOTAL ESTIMATED**

VALUE AFTER THE TRIAL:

\$26,230,000.00 Job 42:16 (NKJV) *"After this lived Job an hundred and forty years, and saw his sons, and his sons' sons, even four generations."* Job was 70 years old when his trial began, and he lived to be 210 years old! God gave him twice as much life following his head-on collision with the devil, than he had before his problems! Think about that, God doubled his life span! Trusting God pay's off in a big way!

Life will no doubt deal us some pain and others will lend a helping hand. What life and others do not do we will create for ourselves. Though there will be pain throughout our lives the real question is, **can we trust God in the painful times? (LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL THE END OF THE SERVICE)** If we cannot position ourselves to trust God in the painful experiences of life we will never become what our Heavenly Father planned for us to be. If we can learn to trust God even though there are painful experiences, we can become everything He has purposed for our lives!

Trust God in the painful experiences of life!

V. IN EVERY EXPERIENCE WE SHOULD THANK GOD!

1 Thessalonians 5:16-18 (NKJV) *"Rejoice always,*

¹⁷pray without ceasing, ¹⁸in everything give thanks; for this is the will of God in Christ Jesus for you.”

In this series of sermons we have been looking at how we should respond when life comes at us with all kinds of experiences and challenges. The [life experiences we have discussed and the proper responses are:](#)

(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- In happy experiences we should praise God...
- In difficult experiences we should seek God...
- In quiet experiences we should worship God...

Today we are going to talk about trusting God in the painful experiences of life.

asing, ¹⁸in everything give thanks; for this is the will of God in Christ Jesus for you.”

While all of these experiences are real and come with their own set of unique challenges, the one common thread which should run the length and breadth of them is the fact that we are going to give thanks to God in all the experiences of life!

In writing to the Thessalonians the Apostle lets them know that they are to **“Rejoice always”** and **“Give thanks in everything!”** What? Could he really mean what he is saying? What about the difficult experiences? What about the painful experiences? Surely he did not mean to **“Rejoice”** and **“Give thanks”** during times such as these! Did he?

The Apostle Paul had full knowledge of the perplexities which life can throw at us! 2 Corinthians 11:23-28 (NKJV) *“I am more: in labors more abundant, in stripes above measure, in prisons more frequently, in deaths often. ²⁴From the Jews five times I received forty stripes minus one. ²⁵Three times I was beaten with rods; once I was stoned; three times I was shipwrecked; a night and a day I have been in the deep; ²⁶in journeys often, in perils of waters, in perils of robbers, in perils of my own countrymen, in perils of the Gentiles, in perils in the city, in perils in the wilderness, in perils in the sea, in perils among false brethren; ²⁷in weariness and toil, in sleeplessness often, in hunger and thirst, in fastings often, in cold and nakedness— ²⁸besides the other things, what comes upon me daily: my deep concern for all the churches.”* Anyone want to match experiences with Paul? Yet he is the same one who said, *“Rejoice always... Give thanks in all things.”*

After Paul had endured all that the devil, life, the religious hierarchy, as well as the suspicion which the church had thrown into his path, how could he say such a thing?

Everything in our lives comes down to two things:
(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- Either we believe our lives are in the hand of God or we don't...

- We place our faith in Him or we attempt to control our own destiny...

When we decide to trust God we must come to the place where we are content to leave the details of the journey to Him and Him alone! Psalms 37:23-25 (NKJV) ***“The steps of a good man are ordered by the LORD, And He delights in his way. ²⁴ Though he fall, he shall not be utterly cast down; For the LORD upholds him with His hand. ²⁵ I have been young, and now am old; Yet I have not seen the righteous forsaken, Nor his descendants begging bread.”***

Life becomes much simpler and less complicated when we come to the understanding that God is in charge of our lives, and nothing can happen to us apart from His permission! William Culbertson said, ***“Keep praying, but be thankful that God's answers are wiser than your prayers!”*** (LEAVE ON THE SCREEN UNTIL THE NEXT SLIDE)

One cannot reach a place of ***“Rejoicing always”*** and ***“Giving thanks in everything”*** until we come to a place where our lives are resting completely in the hands of the Lord! Isaiah 26:3 (NKJV) ***“You will keep him in perfect peace, whose mind is stayed on You, Because he trusts in You.”***

Paul gives us a little insight into the secret of reaching a point where no matter what

experience in life we happen to be navigating, we can ***“Rejoice always”*** and ***“Give thanks in everything.”*** Philippians 4:11-13 (NKJV) ***“I have learned in whatever state I am, to be content: ¹²I know how to be abased, and I know how to abound. Everywhere and in all things I have learned both to be full and to be hungry, both to abound and to suffer need. ¹³I can do all things through Christ who strengthens me.”***

One of the greatest compliments we could ever give to God is to become so contented with our lives that we never hit the panic button! **True contentment in the life of the Christian expresses: (PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Total dependence on God...
- Trust in God to work things out...
- Faith toward God for everything...

When we reach this point in our walk with God, ***“Rejoicing always”*** and ***“Giving thanks in everything”*** trusting God is no longer something one has to work at, but trust and faith flows freely from the inner person!

Remember everything that Paul endured? Listen to what he says in Acts 20:24: (NKJV) ***“But none of these things move me; nor do I count my life dear to myself, so that I may finish my race with joy, and the ministry which I received from the Lord Jesus, to testify to the gospel of the grace of God.”***

The recipe for living a life of “*Rejoicing always*” and “*Giving thanks in everything*” is simply: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

- Use an extra large portion of dependence upon God...
- Apply an equal measure of trust in the Lord...
- Stir in a pinch or two of faith for every situation we face...
- Mix thoroughly with enough persistence for good consistency...
- Let all this settle until “*Rejoicing*” and “*Thanksgiving*” begin to emerge!

**CONGRATULATIONS YOU HAVE
PROPERLY RESPONDED TO THE
EXPERIENCES OF LIFE!**